

What Deserves to Become Vivid?

A first essay, and a master question.

Sit with your day, late, and try to recall it. The meeting that mattered, the conversation with your daughter, the decision you actually made: these come back hazily, in outline. What comes back vividly is a forty-second video of a stranger you will never meet, still playing behind your eyes. The day's most vivid contents are not the day's most important contents. This is now true for almost everyone I know who is responsible for anything. It is worth refusing to look away from.

What we call "the day" is not the sequence of things that happened. It is the sequence of things that became vivid. The unwatched film of an afternoon (the boring, in-between, mostly automatic minutes) is not really the day. The day is whatever rose, in your inner life, with enough texture to leave a mark. When you say *today was hard*, you mean some small set of things became vivid in a particular register. When you say *I cannot stop thinking about it*, you mean something has become vivid against your will. Vividness is the currency of inner life. It is what the mind spends and what the mind has.

Until quite recently, vividness was expensive. Something became vivid because you sat with it. You repeated it. You returned to a face, a sentence, a memory, an unresolved problem. There was a metabolic cost to making something occupy the inner room. The cost ensured a kind of natural scarcity, and the scarcity ensured a kind of selection: the things that became vivid in a life were, more often than not, the things that person had chosen, slowly and sometimes unconsciously.

That is no longer true.

The Attachment Economy is not in the business of capturing attention. It is in the business of producing vividness on demand. Its products do not merely interrupt your day. They install themselves in your inner life and continue to play after the device is closed. A grievance from a comment thread, a face from a feed, a phrase from an algorithmic recommendation: these become as vivid as anything you have ever chosen to dwell on, and they did not require your dwelling. They were delivered pre-vivid. The metabolic cost was paid by someone else's optimization loop.

AI now adds a second layer. The promise of intelligent tools is that everything becomes legible. Every option, every market, every face, every paragraph of every book, instantly retrievable, instantly summarized, instantly available to be pulled into the foreground. A world in which everything is legible is a world in which nothing is naturally obscure. And when nothing is naturally obscure, the discriminative act, *this rises, that recedes*, has to be performed by a person, deliberately, against an enormous tide of plausibly relevant material.

This is the situation in which the central question of this letter becomes practical rather than rhetorical.

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Not: what is true. Not: what is interesting. Not: what is accessible. Those questions used to be hard. AI has largely answered them. Almost anything you might want to know is now legible to you at the cost of a sentence. The hard question, the one that has quietly migrated from the edges of life toward its center, is the question of vividness. Of all the things that could occupy the texture of an afternoon, a marriage, a decision, a decade: which ones rise? Which ones get to feel real?

Attention is the act of consenting to be shaped. What you attend to, repeatedly, becomes you: your judgment, your reflexes, your moral seriousness, the cast of your imagination. The question of what deserves to become vivid is therefore not a question about productivity or focus or even self-discipline. It is a question about consent. To allow something to become vivid in you is to assent to its slow work of formation.

A great deal of what is vivid in most operators' inner lives right now was never assented to. It was installed.

This matters in a specific way for the people this letter is written for.

If you are responsible for consequential decisions (running a company, sitting on a board, raising a child, allocating capital, advising a founder), your judgment is bottlenecked by what you can picture. You will not weigh a risk you cannot picture. You will not protect a person whose face you cannot bring clearly to mind. You will not pursue a vision that has not yet become vivid enough, in your own inner life, to feel real. The operator's tools are not lists. They are images: the customer's actual Tuesday morning, the engineer's actual

frustration in the sprint that is failing, the eight-year-old's actual evening on the couch beside a parent who is somewhere else. A leader's caliber is, to a surprising degree, a function of which images he or she has allowed to become vivid.

In a world of cheap, abundant, manufactured vividness, the leader whose inner life has been colonized by whatever was loudest this week is not making the decisions they think they are making. They are making the decisions their feeds have prepared them to make. This is true at the level of strategy, where the wrong competitor becomes vivid and the actual customer recedes. It is true at the level of personnel, where a single Slack thread becomes vivid and the quietly capable senior person, who never causes friction, recedes. It is true at the level of family, where the project becomes vivid and the child's sentence at the dinner table (the one that mattered, the one you will remember in ten years if you are lucky enough to remember it at all) recedes.

The recovery, then, has to be specific.

It is not a posture of withdrawal. The Voluntary Mind is not a monastery; it is an operating discipline for people still inside the world. The recovery is the deliberate practice of the discriminative act: choosing, against the tide, which images, which faces, which sentences, which problems are allowed to occupy the inner room. *This, not that.* Repeated daily. Over years.

A small practice, to begin.

At the end of a day, not as audit, not as scoring, but as calibration, ask two questions. *Of what became vivid for me today, how much did I choose?* And: *What should have become vivid that did not?*

The first is a question of consent. It will surface, sometimes uncomfortably, the degree to which your inner life is now being curated by parties whose interests are not yours. The second is a question of fidelity. It will surface the people and problems and possibilities you owe attention to: the ones whose claim on your inner life is real, the ones you let slide because something cheaper rose first.

Both questions get sharper with practice. Neither resolves. They are not meant to.

The things that deserve to become vivid in a life rarely push to be. The forty-second video pushes. The grievance pushes. The notification pushes. The child's sentence at the dinner

table does not push. The early signal in the company does not push. The slow truth about the marriage does not push. They wait. They are easy to miss. They have to be selected toward.

This is the master question of the letters that will follow. Each will turn it in a different light (toward leadership, toward parenting, toward AI, toward judgment, toward the operator's inner life), but the question itself does not change.

What deserves to become vivid?

If the answer is not yours, the life is not quite yours either.

The Voluntary Mind · Attention sovereignty for the AI era.